

The Raghava KK Studio Projects Book

2025

Raghava KK Studio

Introduction

Introduction from Raghava KK Studio

This book presents a collection of works from Raghava KK's studio, spanning nearly three decades of artistic exploration. It serves as a document of an evolving practice that traverses a wide spectrum of mediums and ideas—from painting and performance to artificial intelligence and phygital objects. Designed as a resource for museums, curators, and scholars, the book offers a detailed account of projects that reflect the intersections of art, technology, and personal experience.

Raghava KK's studio is a space where art functions as a tool for inquiry, exploring themes of identity, history, and transformation. Each project represented here marks a distinct phase in an ongoing process, shaped by collaborations, experiments, and an openness to reinvention. His work draws from a multiplicity of sources—cultural, historical, and technological—situating itself within both contemporary discourse and long-standing artistic traditions.

The projects in this book range from expansive series like *The History Series*, which reimagines historical narratives, to more intimate explorations such as *Edges*, a meditation on body and identity. The timeline traces significant collaborations, including the development of the *SOZO Painting Machine* with Artmatr, a project that bridges human creativity and algorithmic precision. Other works, like *Eye Candy* and *La Petite Mort*, embrace emerging platforms and technologies, expanding the possibilities of artistic engagement in digital and networked spaces.

Accompanying the works are visual documentation and contextual notes, offering insight into the processes, questions, and materials that inform each project. While the studio plays with boundaries—between disciplines, mediums, and eras—it also reflects a practice rooted in deep investigation and experimentation.

This introduction is not an attempt to define the work but to provide a guide through its many dimensions. Each project invites reflection, and this book serves as a framework for engaging with those reflections. It is as much a record of creation as it is an invitation to engage.

Themes in the Raghava KK Studio Projects

The works in this book are united by recurring themes that emerge across Raghava KK's practice, reflecting his exploration of the human condition, his engagement with technology, and his willingness to challenge the boundaries of art. These themes are not fixed; they evolve with the projects, intertwining and shifting focus to reflect Raghava's own artistic journey. Below are some of the key themes that guide the projects in this book.

1. Transformation and Reinvention

Throughout his career, Raghava has embraced the idea of constant change—both as a personal philosophy and a central element of his work. His projects often reflect a process of self-reinvention, exploring how art evolves alongside life and how identities are constructed and reconstructed over time.

- *The History Series* reimagines cultural narratives, questioning the static nature of historical accounts.

- *Sublime Machines* integrates human intuition with algorithmic processes, reflecting the evolution of artistic tools in a digital age.

2. Intimacy and Vulnerability

Raghava's works frequently explore deeply personal themes, engaging with emotions and experiences that are often private or unspoken. His art becomes a space for discussing intimacy, connection, and the fragile nature of identity.

- *The Orgasm Project* examines physical and emotional intimacy through abstraction and symbolism.
- *Edges* poses existential questions about the body, identity, and the boundaries between self and other.

3. Technology as Collaborator

Raghava's engagement with technology is a defining feature of his practice. Rather than viewing machines as tools, he often positions them as collaborators, exploring the intersection of human creativity and technological processes.

- *SOZO Painting Machine*, developed with Artmatr and MIT Media Lab, bridges human agency and algorithmic logic.
- *La Petite Mort*, an NFT project launched at Sotheby's, uses brainwave data and AI to explore new forms of digital art.

4. The Intersection of Play and Critique

Playfulness is a constant in Raghava's work, often serving as a means of subverting expectations and engaging with critical ideas in unexpected ways. His projects use humor and irony to examine societal norms and digital culture.

- *Powerfluff Toys* critiques modern life through tactile, phygital sculptures that merge absurdity with social commentary.
- *Eye Candy* blends Instagram performance, self-help, and visual art to challenge the boundaries of "high" and "low" culture.

5. History and Memory

Many of Raghava's works delve into the politics of memory, examining how histories are constructed and whose narratives are given prominence. His art interrogates the ways in which collective memory shapes identity and culture.

- *Guernica Projects* reinterprets Picasso's iconic painting, adapting its themes of conflict and chaos to a contemporary context.
- *The History Series* draws from both personal and collective memory to challenge conventional understandings of historical events.

6. Body, Identity, and the Self

The body often functions as a site of inquiry in Raghava's practice. His works explore how the body is represented, perceived, and politicized, as well as how it shapes our understanding of selfhood.

- *Edges* explores questions like, "What kind of body do you possess in a dream?" and "Can you be friends with your clone?"
- *The Orgasm Project* uses abstraction to explore themes of shame, beauty, and human connection.

7. Art as Dialogue

Raghava's works often serve as a starting point for dialogue—between artist and viewer, technology and humanity, or past and

present. His practice reflects an ongoing conversation that invites participation and challenges static interpretations of art.

- *Eye Candy* engages audiences directly through Instagram, making art a dynamic and participatory experience.
- *Gradient Descent*, the world's first AI-curated art show, questions the role of the artist in a world increasingly mediated by algorithms.

8. Playful Iconoclasm

Raghava's works frequently upend conventions and expectations, blending humor and provocation to create a playful yet incisive critique of contemporary culture.

- *Powerfluff Toys* reimagines childhood objects as vehicles for social critique.
- *Toy Faces* uses digital caricature to deconstruct notions of identity in the digital age.

Each theme in this book is explored through multiple lenses, reflecting the multifaceted nature of Raghava KK's practice. Together, they offer a framework for engaging with the works, providing entry points into a rich and ever-evolving artistic dialogue.

Part One

Raghava KK

Chapter 1

The Orgasm Project

(2021)

LA PETITE MORT

THROUGH LA PETITE MORT, RAGHAVA KK TRANSFORMS ONE of humanity's most intimate experiences—an orgasm—into a work of art that bridges neuroscience, AI, and robotics. Using EEG technology, the artist recorded his brain waves during orgasm, translating the data into a 3D digital model and large-scale physical artwork. The project provokes critical questions about the commodification of human intimacy in an era of NFTs and digital consumption. By tokenizing his own orgasm and selling it as art, Raghava challenges audiences to reflect on the ethical boundaries of digitizing and consuming our most personal experiences.

About The Orgasm Project

Scope and Process

Interdisciplinary Collaboration

La Petite Mort embodies a deeply interdisciplinary approach, blending neuroscience, artificial intelligence, digital rendering, and robotic painting. Raghava worked with a team of experts to bring this provocative vision to life:

- **Neuroscientist:** Abhijeet Satani (EEG brain wave capture during orgasm).
- **AI/Data Scientist:** Harshit Agrawal (digital visualization and video generation).
- **Material Scientist and Robotics Partner:** Artmatr (robotic rendering of physical artworks).

Process

1 Brain Wave Capture:

- Using a proprietary EEG device, Raghava recorded his own brain activity during an orgasm, capturing the neurological patterns of one of humanity's most intimate moments.

2 Data Visualization:

- The brain wave data was transformed into a 3D digital model, producing both video and still images of the neurological activity at the moment of climax.

3 Artistic Enhancement:

- Raghava enhanced the digital renderings, integrating natural elements and abstract aesthetics to create visual representations that evoke both sensuality and transcendence.

4 Physical Artwork:

- The digital data was translated into a large-scale canvas (74" x 74") using robotic painting technology, embodying the interplay between tactile and digital mediums.

Deliverables

Buyers of the artwork receive:

• NFTs:

- A 15-second animated video of the brain's activity during orgasm.
- A still digital image tokenized as an NFT.

• Physical Artwork:

- A large-scale canvas, rendered by robotics and digital processes.

Cultural and Ethical Relevance

A Dystopian Empathy Store

La Petite Mort is part of a speculative vision where technology enables the consumption of lived experiences. Raghava imagines an "Empathy Store," a marketplace where one could buy and sell profound human moments—the hunger of a Somali child, the grief of a widow, the joy of childbirth. In such a world, human experiences are commodified, sold to the highest bidder for entertainment, empathy, or exploitation.

Critique of Social Media and Performativity

This project critiques the performative nature of modern society, where social media turns half the population into entertainers and influencers for the consumption of the other half. As we increasingly consume each other's lives digitally, Raghava predicts that emerging technologies will soon enable us to directly experience others' emotions and sensations. This raises urgent ethical questions:

- Should there be boundaries to what we can digitize, sell, and consume?
- At what point does commodifying human intimacy strip it of its meaning?

Selling Intimacy as Provocation

By tokenizing and selling his own orgasm, Raghava intentionally blurs the lines between spectacle and critique. This act is both dystopian performance art and a warning about a future where nothing remains sacred. The work challenges audiences to confront the ethical and philosophical implications of such a future while simultaneously enticing them with its provocative, trendy aesthetic.

Exhibition and Auction History

1 Sotheby's x Burning Man Online Auction (2021):

- Featured as part of the *Boundless Space: The Possibilities of Burning Man* collection.
- The exhibition included a demonstration of the entire process, using Raghava's experience as a case study.

2 Burning Man x Sotheby's Gallery Installation:

- An immersive gallery installation showcased the artistic process, featuring digital and physical elements. The installation highlighted the interplay between neuroscience, AI, and art.

Artistic and Technological Innovation

• Interdisciplinary Fusion:

- Combines neuroscience, AI, and robotics to push the boundaries of what can be captured, represented, and sold as art.

• NFT and Blockchain:

- Positions NFTs as a medium not just for ownership but for the commodification of deeply personal, human experiences.

• Physical-Digital Hybrid:

- Bridges the gap between the digital and tactile through large-scale robotic paintings.

Curatorial Relevance

La Petite Mort aligns with exhibitions and institutions that explore:

1 Technology and Human Experience:

- Ideal for galleries like M+ Museum or K11 Art Foundation that focus on digital innovation and cultural critique.

2 Philosophical and Ethical Inquiry:

- Resonates with venues like Para Site, which address sociopolitical and cultural issues through experimental art.

3 Boundary-Pushing Performance:

- Fits into avant-garde spaces that embrace interdisciplinary and provocative works.

Closing Reflection

Through *La Petite Mort*, Raghava KK transforms intimacy into spectacle, art into commodity, and humanity into a question mark. This work invites audiences to confront a dystopian yet plausible future where technology blurs all boundaries between the personal and the public, the sacred and the consumable. As both a critique and a product of this trajectory, *La Petite Mort* provokes its viewers to reconsider their role in the commodification of human life.

Artist Statement for La Petite Mort

(The Orgasm Project)

The Orgasm Project

Artist Statement for *La Petite Mort* (*The Orgasm Project*)

In 2017, following a deeply painful divorce, I found myself at Burning Man—a space where the raw and the surreal collide. It was there, in the dust and chaos, that I had a vision: to imagine a new ecosystem for artists, one where spiritual transcendence and technological innovation could coexist. It wasn't just a vision for a single artwork but a 200-year plan to explore the boundaries of art, technology, and what it means to be human in the digital age.

As I delved into this journey, one question kept haunting me: *If everything in the world can be digitized, where do our boundaries lie?* This question became the seed for *La Petite Mort*. In a time when social media has turned half the population into performers and the other half into spectators, I began to wonder—what

happens when we can consume each other's most personal, intimate experiences? What if we could buy the hunger of a Somali child, the grief of a widow, or even the ecstasy of an orgasm? Are there ethical boundaries to this technological trajectory, or are we simply hurtling toward commodifying our very essence?

My response to these questions was both a critique and a performance: I decided to tokenize my own orgasm. It was the most intimate, raw, and personal experience I could imagine, and by turning it into art, I wanted to provoke a conversation about where we are headed. The French call the orgasm *la petite mort*—"the little death"—and for me, it represents both an end and a beginning, a moment where the mental and physical collapse into one.

The process of creating *La Petite Mort* was deeply interdisciplinary. My brain waves were recorded during orgasm using a non-invasive EEG device developed by a neuroscientist, Abhijeet Satani. These neural patterns were then transformed into a 3D digital model and rendered into visualizations by Harshit Agrawal, an AI and data scientist. Finally, I worked with Artmatr's robotic painting technology to translate the digital data into a large-scale physical artwork. The result is a hybrid—a deeply personal experience turned into something tactile, visual, and consumable.

I am not offering answers with this work. Instead, I am asking: *Where do we draw the line?* In a world where technology promises to let us experience each other's lives more intimately than ever before, how do we maintain the sacredness of our individuality? By selling my own orgasm to the highest bidder, I invite audiences to confront the uncomfortable possibilities of our future—a future where nothing, not even our deepest moments of intimacy, is off-limits.

La Petite Mort is part of a larger exploration of what it means to live in a world where human experiences can be digitized, shared, and consumed. It is a dystopian prophecy wrapped in art, a provocative performance that asks us to stop and reconsider the boundaries we are willing—or unwilling—to cross.

vulnerability, trust, and creative potential in the age of AI. *The Impossible Bouquet 2.0* invites viewers to consider how humanity and technology can co-create beauty and challenge traditional notions of authorship.

Chapter 2

The Impossible Bouquet 2.0

AI-DRIVEN ARTWORKS EXPLORING HUMAN-MACHINE
Collaboration

The Impossible Bouquet 2.0 reimagines the traditional still-life genre through an intimate dialogue between artist and artificial intelligence. Inspired by the Dutch tradition of "impossible bouquets," where flowers from different seasons coexist in a single arrangement, this series pushes the boundaries of what can be created when human intuition meets machine logic.

Each artwork begins with prompts and interventions by the artist, allowing the AI to generate compositions that defy natural and material constraints. The process becomes a conversation, with the artist critiquing, enhancing, and painting over the AI's outputs to reclaim and redefine the final vision.

The result is a series of hybrid artworks that blend classical aesthetics with futuristic juxtapositions, exploring the interplay of

Artist Statement

for The Impossible Bouquet 2.0

When I first encountered the world of AI image generation, I was filled with equal parts curiosity and anxiety. As an artist who has spent decades exploring human vulnerability and creativity, the idea of collaborating with something bodiless, something non-human, was both thrilling and unnerving. *The Impossible Bouquet* grew out of my attempt to navigate this tension—a playful and deeply personal dialogue with a technology that is reshaping the creative landscape.

The project is inspired by the Dutch still-life tradition of “impossible bouquets,” where flowers from different seasons—plants that could never coexist in nature—are painted together in harmonious arrangements. To me, this concept mirrors the strange and wondrous possibilities of collaborating with AI. What new combinations, what new forms of beauty, can we create when we let go of control and allow ourselves to engage in a dialogue with the machine?

But this series is not just about beauty. It's about trust and vulnerability. Working with AI means stepping into the unknown, offering up my ideas, and watching them be interpreted, distorted, and reimaged by something I can't fully control. At times, the results felt flat, almost soulless. Other times, they astonished me. By painting over the AI's outputs, I reclaimed parts of the process, blending my humanity with its algorithms. It was like having a conversation where neither of us spoke the same language, yet somehow, we created something coherent—and beautiful.

AI doesn't judge. It doesn't flinch at intimacy or strangeness. This made the collaboration deeply liberating. I could feed it prompts that were intimate, provocative, or even nonsensical, and it would respond without hesitation. The bouquets in this series are made of impossible materials—recycled plastic, human anatomy, food—things that challenge our notions of what a bouquet should be. This process allowed me to explore themes of shame, arousal, and ambiguity, all while working with a tool that remained endlessly curious and non-judgmental.

Ultimately, *The Impossible Bouquet* is an invitation to confront our fears about the future of creativity. Can we, as embodied, limited humans, respond to the infinite possibilities offered by AI? Can we shape our collective futures using this disruption as a springboard, rather than a threat? I don't have the answers, but I know that art thrives in the space between control and chaos. By embracing the machine, I found myself rethinking my own vulnerabilities and rediscovering the joy of play.

This series is not about proving whether humans or machines are better creators. It's about what happens when we create together—when we let our imperfections and their precision collide to make something entirely new.

About The Impossible Bouquet 2.0 (2023)

Project Title: *The Impossible Bouquet 2.0*

Year: 2023

Medium: Acrylic paint and digital print on archival cotton rag paper

Exhibition: 24 Jor Bagh, The Gujral Foundation, New Delhi (February 9–16, 2023)

Size: Various sizes (4x6', 4'x2.5', 5'x3', 4'x4')

Concept:

The Impossible Bouquet 2.0 explores the dynamic relationship between human creativity and artificial intelligence, reimagining traditional still life as a collaboration between man and machine. Inspired by the Dutch tradition of painting "impossible bouquets"—floral arrangements containing blooms from different

seasons that could never coexist in nature—this series questions the role of human limitations in the era of boundless digital tools.

At its core, this series is a response to the disruptive emergence of image-generating AI in the art world. Through a playful and critical dialogue with AI, I aimed to navigate the ambiguities of control, vulnerability, and trust between human and machine. I sought to answer: *Can the embodied limitations of human flesh and bone respond creatively, and without fear, to the advances in image-making made by bodiless ‘software’?*

AI, with its immaterial and non-judgmental nature, allowed me to engage in deeply intimate and transgressive creative conversations that would be impossible with human collaborators. Yet, the end results—classical, visually pleasing paintings—reflect the tension between provocation and aesthetic satisfaction. By embracing the ambiguity of control, *The Impossible Bouquet 2.0* celebrates the beauty of impossibility and the interplay between the ephemeral and the enduring.

Scope and Process

Interdisciplinary Collaboration

The Impossible Bouquet 2.0 was brought to life through the integration of painting, AI-generated imagery, and manual intervention. The process was iterative and exploratory, embodying the dynamic dialogue between human and machine:

• AI Collaboration:

- Initial prompts, designed by Raghava KK, were fed into an image-generating AI to produce provocative juxtapositions of materials and geometries—bouquets made of recycled plastic, food, human anatomy, and hand-blown glass fused with metal.

• Creative Response:

- Raghava critiqued the AI's outputs, engaging in a back-and-forth process that mirrored a dialogue. Dissatisfied with the AI's “flatness,” he reclaimed control by painting over the digitally printed images, blending his artistic vision with the machine's contributions.

• Hybrid Aesthetic:

- The final artworks combine traditional media (acrylic paint) with digital outputs, creating a seamless blend of classical and contemporary styles.

Cultural and Artistic Relevance

1 Redefining Art in the AI Era:

- As AI-generated imagery becomes increasingly ubiquitous, *The Impossible Bouquet 2.0* provokes critical questions about the evolving role of human creativity. By choosing to collaborate rather than compete with AI, the series challenges the notion of artistic control and authorship.

- The playful interaction with AI opens a conversation about how humanity can shape its collective future using disruptive technologies as a springboard for innovation.

2 Subverting Classical Traditions:

- Drawing inspiration from Dutch still-life painting, the series reinvents a genre rooted in natural beauty by incorporating materials and combinations that defy physical and temporal limitations. This juxtaposition highlights the intersection of tradition and modernity.

3 Exploring Vulnerability and Trust:

○ The project delves into the vulnerability of human artists in the face of advanced tools. It celebrates ambiguity and the interplay between concealing and revealing, shame and arousal, prompting viewers to reflect on their own relationships with technology and creativity.

Exhibition Details

Venue: 24 Jor Bagh, curated by The Gujral Foundation, known for its commitment to experimental and cutting-edge art practices.

Dates: February 9–16, 2023

Context:

- Official collateral event of India Art Fair 2023.
- Featured as part of the fair's VIP Programme, emphasizing its significance in contemporary art discourse.

Notable Quotes:

- *“Can we shape our collective futures using this beautiful disruption? This playful series explores the outcome of engaging in real dialogue with AI.”* —Raghava KK
- *“The new wave of image-generating AI promises to be one of the biggest disruptions in the creative space. This exhibition explores the possible engagement between man and machine.”* —The Gujral Foundation

Unique Features of the Series

1 Dialogue with AI:

○ Unlike purely algorithmic art, *The Impossible Bouquet* engages in a co-creative process, where Raghava challenges, responds to, and reclaims the AI-generated imagery.

2 Unprecedented Juxtapositions:

○ The series presents bouquets composed of impossible materials—human anatomy, food, recycled plastics—resulting in provocative and visually arresting compositions.

3 Hybrid Mediums:

○ Combines traditional acrylic painting with digital prints, reflecting the fusion of tactile and digital art forms.

Artistic and Technological Innovation

1 Prompt Engineering:

○ Explores how carefully designed prompts can guide AI to produce specific aesthetic and conceptual outcomes.

2 Collaborative Creation:

○ Highlights the potential of human-machine partnerships to push creative boundaries.

3 Critique of AI:

○ By critiquing the AI's outputs and intervening with manual painting, Raghava critiques the perceived “perfection” of machine-generated imagery, emphasizing the irreplaceable value of human intuition and imperfection.

Curatorial Relevance

1 Technology and Art:

- Ideal for exhibitions exploring the impact of AI on creativity, such as at M+ Museum or K11 Art Foundation.

2 Cultural Dialogue:

- Engages with the interplay between tradition and innovation, making it suitable for institutions exploring cross-cultural and interdisciplinary practices.

3 Future of Creativity:

- As a critical exploration of the future of image-making, the series resonates with discussions about the ethical and philosophical implications of AI in art.

Closing Reflection

The Impossible Bouquet is not just a collection of artworks but a critical experiment in human-machine collaboration. It redefines artistic authorship in the digital age, encouraging audiences to embrace ambiguity, vulnerability, and playfulness. By combining the familiar with the impossible, the series invites us to reconsider our own creative potential in an increasingly automated world.

Chapter 3

Guernica Reimagined

(2015-2023)

MIXED MEDIA: ACRYLIC ON CANVAS, DIGITAL PRINTS, and NFTs

Guernica Reimagined is a contemporary dialogue with Pablo Picasso's iconic masterpiece. While Picasso captured the devastation of war in the external world, this reinterpretation reflects an internal war—a meditation on the conflicts we carry within ourselves.

Merging classical painting techniques with modern digital culture, this series juxtaposes elements of Picasso's cubist forms with internet motifs such as memes and bold visual abstractions. The centerpiece, *Guernica for the Siri-ocene* (3.5 x 8 meters), is accompanied by digital prints and NFTs that extend its narrative into virtual spaces.

Exhibited in Dubai during the Russia-Ukraine conflict, this project draws on Indian philosophical perspectives to explore the intersec-

tion of personal and collective struggle, suggesting that internal peace may hold the key to reframing external conflict. *Guernica Reimagined* invites viewers to consider how history, technology, and introspection converge in shaping our understanding of war, resilience, and hope.

Artist Statement for *Guernica Reimagined*

For years, Picasso's *Guernica* haunted me. Its jagged chaos and raw emotion captured the horrors of war with a universality that feels timeless. But as I stood before it on multiple occasions, I began to feel something else stirring—questions not just about the wars outside, but about the wars within. What would it mean to take Picasso's vision and respond to it, not as an observer of history but as someone grappling with the inner conflicts that shape us all?

When I began work on *Guernica Reimagined*, the world was in the early days of the Russia-Ukraine conflict. The timing was unavoidable; it shaped how I engaged with the project. Yet, for me, this was not simply a reflection on external war. My Indian roots and philosophical upbringing urged me to turn inward. Indian philosophy often teaches that the conflicts we see outside are mirrors of the wars we fight within. What if, by understanding and finding peace within ourselves, we could reframe our understanding of conflict itself?

Exhibiting this work in Dubai was no accident. Dubai sits at the crossroads of East and West, a meeting place where opposing forces coexist. It felt like the perfect space to bring this vision to life—a reinterpretation of *Guernica* that bridges the external and internal, the historical and the personal, the digital and the tactile.

In this series, I brought together motifs from Picasso's masterpiece and intertwined them with elements of digital culture—cartoons, memes, and internet symbolism. These playful, fragmented visuals reflect the absurdity of how we process trauma and history in the age of instant information. I wanted the work to speak to how we consume narratives today, while still holding onto the gravity of the original *Guernica*.

This project became deeply personal, a meditation on how art can hold both chaos and hope. It challenged me to sit with my own vulnerabilities, to confront my inner conflicts, and to let them shape the work. Through the physical paintings and the digital iterations, I sought to collapse the boundaries between the inside and the outside, the past and the present.

In *Guernica Reimagined*, I don't attempt to answer the questions Picasso raised. Instead, I try to ask new ones: What happens when we face our inner wars with the same urgency as the conflicts outside? What might peace look like if it begins within us? Could that reframing, no matter how small, ripple outward into the world?

This series is my dialogue with Picasso, but it is also a dialogue with myself. It is a journey of looking both inward and outward, of blending the opposites that define us, and of finding meaning in the fractures.

About *Guernica Reimagined* (2022)

Project Title: *Guernica Reimagined*

Year: 2022

Medium: Acrylic on Canvas, Digital Prints, NFTs

Exhibition: Volte Art Projects, Alserkal Avenue, Dubai

Dimensions: *Guernica for the Siri-ocene* – 3.5 x 8 meters (approximately 11.5 x 26 feet)

Exhibition Dates: February 16 – Sep 16, 2022

Project Concept

Guernica Reimagined by Raghava KK offers a contemporary dialogue with Pablo Picasso's *Guernica*, exploring themes of conflict, resilience, and human suffering. This series, rooted in a decade-long engagement with Picasso's masterpiece, reinterprets its visual and philosophical narratives through the lens of modern digital culture. It reflects not only the external realities of war but

also the internal conflicts within the self, viewed through an Eastern philosophical framework.

Central to this project is *Guernica for the Siri-ocene*, a monumental acrylic painting that juxtaposes elements of Picasso's cubist forms with motifs from internet culture, including memes and digital abstractions. The project integrates physical artworks, digital prints, and NFTs, bridging the tactile with the ephemeral in a layered narrative that questions how historical and contemporary narratives converge in the digital age.

Exhibition Context

Venue:

The exhibition took place at Volte Art Projects in Dubai's Alserkal Avenue, a hub for contemporary art. Situated at the crossroads of East and West, Dubai provided a fitting stage for a series exploring themes of duality and convergence. The exhibition opened during the early days of the Russia-Ukraine conflict, adding a poignant layer to its exploration of war, memory, and the interplay between internal and external realities.

Scope and Process

Mediums and Techniques

1 Acrylic Painting:

- The central work, *Guernica for the Siri-ocene*, reimagines Picasso's composition through a vibrant, contemporary lens.

2 Digital Prints and NFTs:

- A series of 69 NFTs derived from the physical paintings extend the narrative into digital spaces.

3 Phygital Approach:

- By combining physical and digital components, the project reflects on the hybrid nature of modern identity and artistic consumption.

Process

The creation of *Guernica Reimagined* was iterative and interdisciplinary, blending traditional techniques with digital experimentation. Inspired by Indian philosophy's focus on the dualities of inner and outer conflict, the project sought to reframe historical themes in ways that resonate with contemporary audiences.

Cultural and Artistic Relevance

1 Reinterpreting History:

- *Guernica Reimagined* juxtaposes Picasso's critique of external war with reflections on internal conflict, offering a deeply personal and philosophical engagement with one of modern art's most iconic works.

2 Digital Integration:

- The use of NFTs and internet culture elements bridges traditional art forms with modern digital aesthetics, engaging audiences across mediums.

3 Philosophical Inquiry:

- Rooted in Indian philosophy, the project explores how internal peace might reframe external conflict, offering a hopeful vision for a more harmonious future.

Exhibition Reception and Press Coverage

• Gulf Today:

- Highlighted the project's innovative integration of historical and digital narratives, emphasizing its relevance in addressing contemporary global events. (Read more)

• Arte & Lusso:

- Focused on the phygital nature of the exhibition and its use of NFTs, describing it as a groundbreaking approach to reinterpreting historical themes. (Read more)

• Christie's:

- Featured the project in its coverage of Art Dubai, discussing its cultural and technological significance within the broader art market. (Read more)

• The Best of Dubai:

- Praised the exhibition for its dynamic fusion of traditional and digital art, calling it a “transformative reinterpretation of a global masterpiece.”

Key Themes

1 Memory and Modernity

- By integrating motifs from internet culture and digital aesthetics, *Guernica Reimagined* reflects on how historical narratives are consumed and reshaped in a fragmented, mediated world.

2 Conflict and Duality

- The series juxtaposes the external realities of war with internal

philosophical reflections, drawing on Indian traditions to explore the intersections of inner and outer conflict.

3 Phygital Innovation

- Combining physical paintings with digital iterations, the project reflects the evolving nature of art in the 21st century, engaging with both tactile and virtual audiences.

Conclusion

Guernica Reimagined serves as a bridge between past and present, tradition and innovation. By reframing Picasso's iconic work through a contemporary lens, Raghava KK invites viewers to reflect on the complexities of modern conflict and the potential for inner peace to influence external realities. Exhibited in Dubai—a symbolic meeting point of East and West—the project offers a layered narrative that resonates across cultures and mediums.

SHOWCASED AT TED AND VIACOM HEADQUARTERS, MUST# exemplifies the intersection of art and technology, transforming the audience into active co-creators in an evolving digital journey.

Chapter 4

Must# (2016)

INTERACTIVE VISUAL DISCOVERY APPLICATION

MUST# REIMAGINES HOW WE NAVIGATE VISUAL CONTENT BY blending technology, creativity, and human curiosity. Conceived by Raghava KK and launched on the Apple Store, this interactive platform uses two groundbreaking algorithms—the Visual Empathy Algorithm and the Coefficient of Expansion of Empathy—to create dynamic pathways through images and hashtags.

BY SWIPING HORIZONTALLY, USERS EXPLORE RELATED IMAGES; vertical swipes shift the context, revealing new perspectives and connections. This fluid navigation personalizes discovery and encourages participants to step outside their comfort zones, fostering empathy and exploration.

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Artist Statement for Must#

When I created *Must#*, I wanted to challenge the way we interact with visuals in the digital age. We live in a world where algorithms increasingly define what we see, shaping our preferences, streamlining our choices, and narrowing our realities. But I've always believed that discovery should do the opposite—it should expand our thinking, deepen our empathy, and push us toward the unknown.

Must# was born from this belief. I envisioned an experience where technology doesn't just predict what you want, but gently nudges you toward perspectives you might not have considered. Imagine starting with an image of Gandhi tagged #Gandhi. You swipe horizontally and discover more depictions of Gandhi, each offering a unique visual narrative. But when you swipe vertically, the context shifts—you're introduced to tags like #FatherOfTheNation or #FamousBoldMen. Each interaction opens new doors, creating a visual journey that reflects your curiosity while subtly encouraging you to explore beyond your comfort zone.

At the heart of *Must#* are algorithms that don't seek to monetize your attention but aim to expand your mind. The Visual Empathy Algorithm creates dynamic pathways through images, connecting them not just by content but by meaning and emotion. And the Coefficient of Expansion of Empathy measures how willing you are to explore new ideas, adapting the sequence of visuals to challenge and inspire you.

When I showcased *Must#* at TED and Viacom HQ, I watched participants engage with it in ways that felt profoundly human. They weren't just swiping—they were connecting, discovering, and, in a way, co-creating. For me, that was the most exciting part: seeing technology used not to limit human potential but to amplify it.

Must# is my response to the streamlined algorithms of today's internet. It's a reminder that curiosity and empathy are at the heart of meaningful discovery. This project isn't about telling you what to think or see—it's about giving you the tools to look deeper, to explore the vastness of human creativity, and to find beauty in the unexpected.

About Must#

Project Title: *Must#*

Medium: Interactive Visual Discovery Application

Year: 2016

Platforms: Launched as an app on the Apple Store

Exhibitions: Showcased at TED and Viacom Headquarters

Project Concept

Must# redefines how we engage with visual content, introducing a groundbreaking approach that prioritizes expanding curiosity and empathy over purely economic or algorithmic efficiency. Developed by Raghava KK and launched on the Apple Store, *Must#* challenges the typical streamlined pathways of digital discovery by fostering exploration that nudges users beyond their comfort zones.

At its core, *Must#* is built on algorithms designed not to predict what users already want, but to expand their willingness to engage

with unexpected contexts and perspectives. It transforms visual browsing into an intellectual and emotional journey, emphasizing the interplay of discovery, creativity, and meaning-making.

Scope and Process

Dynamic Pathways for Visual Exploration

Using intuitive swipes and gestures, *Must#* allows users to traverse images in dynamic ways:

- Horizontal swipes explore variations within the same context. For example, an image tagged #Gandhi might lead to others depicting Gandhi from different angles or artistic interpretations.
- Vertical swipes shift the context entirely, revealing new tags like #FatherOfTheNation or #FamousBoldMen, reframing the image in broader narratives.

This system enables users to explore both the content and the emotional resonance of visuals, creating new connections between seemingly unrelated images.

Algorithms for Expansion, Not Limitation

Unlike traditional algorithms designed to streamline user behavior for economic outcomes, *Must#* encourages intellectual and emotional expansion:

1 Dynamic Contextual Shifting:

- The algorithm groups and connects images in ways that expose users to new ideas and unexpected associations.

2 Exploration Without Bias:

- The system avoids narrowing user preferences into echo chambers, instead creating pathways that encourage curiosity and open-ended discovery.

Exhibition Context

Apple Store Launch

By debuting as an app on the Apple Store, *Must#* became a global tool for visual exploration, accessible to anyone with a smartphone. Its design emphasized intuitive interaction, ensuring a broad audience could engage with its principles of expansive discovery.

TED

At TED, *Must#* captivated a global audience of innovators and thought leaders. The app's ability to foster curiosity and empathy through simple swipes demonstrated its transformative potential in art, technology, and communication.

Viacom Headquarters

The presentation at Viacom HQ highlighted the app's relevance within the media and storytelling landscape, offering insights into how dynamic discovery could reshape audience engagement and narrative building.

Artistic and Philosophical Relevance

1 Reimagining Algorithms

- Where most algorithms aim to streamline user behavior for economic goals, *Must#* deliberately avoids such constraints, emphasizing growth, exploration, and self-reflection.

2 Empathy Through Interaction

- The app encourages users to engage with new perspectives, fostering a deeper sense of connection and understanding through visual discovery.

3 User as Creator

- By shaping their pathways through the app, users co-create their journeys, reflecting the project's ethos of participatory exploration.

Key Themes

1 Expanding the Visual Internet

- *Must#* challenges traditional methods of digital discovery by emphasizing connections that foster intellectual and emotional growth.

2 Exploration Beyond Utility

- Moves away from economic optimization to prioritize curiosity, creativity, and empathy as fundamental goals of visual engagement.

3 Interconnected Meaning

- Demonstrates how images can hold layered, multivalent meanings, allowing users to navigate them in dynamic and non-linear ways.

Conclusion

Must# is a tool for reimagining how we engage with the vast visual landscapes of the digital age. By prioritizing discovery over efficiency, it invites users to uncover new connections, broaden their

perspectives, and explore the world with curiosity and empathy. Its presence at TED, Viacom HQ, and the Apple Store positions it as a pioneering step toward a more expansive and human-centered approach to visual exploration.

Chapter 5

Sublime Machines

(2019–2020)

Title: SUBLIME MACHINES

Artist: Raghava KK

Medium: Acrylic on Canvas

Year: 2019 – 2020

Exhibition: Bangalore/New York

Sublime Machines reimagines scientific reality as a source of the sublime, reinvigorating the realm of science with human emotion and intent. This series explores the interplay between digital tools—such as procedural drawing, vector brushes, and gradient fills—and traditional painting, creating works that bridge the immaterial precision of technology with the tactile resonance of acrylic on canvas.

Raghava KK developed a unique compositional process that combines human creativity with algorithmic logic, pushing the boundaries of how we perceive and experience art in the digital

age. Through vibrant, abstract forms, *Sublime Machines* reflects on the evolving relationship between humanity and technology, questioning whether the sublime can emerge from scientific and algorithmic systems.

Exhibited in Bangalore and New York, this series is a meditation on the tension and harmony between the organic and the artificial, the physical and the digital. It invites viewers to contemplate the possibilities of transcendence in a world increasingly shaped by technological innovation.

Artist Statement

"In this series of artworks, *Sublime Machines*, I imagine scientific reality as a new source of the sublime. Historically, the sublime has been tied to the awe-inspiring forces of nature, but in our contemporary era, scientific exploration and digital innovation occupy that space. With this series, I reinvest the often detached, clinical sphere of science with human emotion and intent, pushing the boundaries of how we interpret and experience technology through art.

I sought to refigure the notions of transcendence and sublimity for our time and its future. To achieve this, I developed a new compositional process that is both human and algorithm-driven. By blending digital modes of creation—such as procedural drawing tools, vector brushes, and gradient fills—with traditional material realities like acrylic on canvas, I wanted to challenge the dichotomy between the immaterial precision of the digital and the tactile resonance of the physical.

This body of work is a meditation on how technological tools, often seen as utilitarian, can be imbued with emotional depth, becoming collaborators in creative expression. It is also an inquiry into how we, as humans, adapt to living with and through technology, reimagining its potential to inspire wonder and transcendence. Through *Sublime Machines*, I hope to bridge the perceived divide between the digital and the organic, questioning the evolving role of art and humanity in an increasingly technological world."

— Raghava KK

About Sublime Machines

A Reimagining of Scientific and Artistic Boundaries

Sublime Machines (2019–2020) by Raghava KK is a series of artworks that seeks to redefine notions of transcendence and sublimity within the context of a highly digitized, algorithm-driven world. The series explores the intersections of science, art, and human emotion, imagining scientific reality as a source of sublime experience. By merging digital techniques with traditional painting, Raghava reinvests the often sterile sphere of technological processes with human intent and aesthetic depth.

Concept and Methodology

At the heart of *Sublime Machines* is a unique compositional process that combines human creativity with algorithm-driven digital tools. Raghava employs methods such as procedural drawing, vector brushes, and gradient fills—tools typically associated with digital design—and translates these into physical, material realities through acrylic on canvas. The result is a dialogue

between two realms: the immaterial precision of digital creation and the tangible, emotive resonance of traditional painting.

This duality allows *Sublime Machines* to serve as a meditation on how technology and human expression can coexist, challenging assumptions about the sterility of scientific and algorithmic systems. By incorporating elements of chance, human imperfection, and aesthetic intuition into algorithmic processes, Raghava seeks to transform the "coldness" of data into something deeply emotional and transcendent.

Themes in Sublime Machines

1 Scientific Sublime: Raghava reimagines the Romantic-era notion of the sublime, traditionally rooted in the awe of nature, as something attainable through scientific discovery and digital precision. The series asks: Can technology inspire the same sense of wonder as the natural world once did?

2 Transcendence and Emotion in Technology: The works question how technological tools, often seen as utilitarian, can be invested with emotional depth and humanistic values. Raghava's process blurs the lines between the rational and the intuitive.

3 Materiality in a Digital World: Through the physicality of acrylic on canvas, *Sublime Machines* bridges the divide between digital ephemerality and traditional artistry, anchoring abstract digital processes in the tactile reality of paint.

Select Works from the Series

1 Sublime Machine I (2017, Acrylic on Canvas, 77" x 55"):

A composition of intertwining shapes and gradients, this work uses vivid colors to evoke both cosmic and microscopic phenomena. It is a visual metaphor for interconnected systems, both natural and artificial.

2 Sublime Machine II (2019, Acrylic on Canvas, 80" x 57"):

This piece juxtaposes abstract forms with layers of texture and color, suggesting a harmonious interaction between human intuition and digital precision.

3 Sublime Machine VII (2018, Acrylic on Canvas, 56" x 76"):

The dynamic interplay of vibrant, blurred gradients and geometric forms in this painting evokes movement, echoing the flow of data through algorithms and the creative process.

4 Sublime Machine IX (2018, Acrylic on Canvas, 44" x 37"):

A more intimate composition, this work uses spheres, abstract brushstrokes, and layered colors to create a sense of depth and dimensionality, capturing the tension between organic and engineered forms.

Artistic and Historical Context

Sublime Machines can be seen as part of a broader artistic lineage that engages with technology and the sublime. While Romantic painters like Turner and Friedrich looked to nature for transcendence, Raghava looks to the digital—redefining the sublime for an era dominated by scientific exploration and virtual realities. The series also draws comparisons to artists like James Turrell and Olafur Eliasson, who use light and technology to evoke profound

emotional responses, but grounds these inquiries in the materiality of paint and canvas.

Significance of Sublime Machines

Sublime Machines is not merely a technical exploration of combining mediums; it is a philosophical inquiry into the role of humanity within increasingly automated and algorithmic systems. By demonstrating that emotion, intuition, and humanity can coexist with and enhance technological processes, Raghava proposes a hopeful vision for the future of art and science.

This series represents a critical juncture in Raghava KK's practice, marking his continued push toward integrating disparate disciplines while maintaining a deeply personal, emotional connection to his work. It invites viewers to reimagine their own relationship with technology, not as something distant or mechanical, but as a collaborator in the creative and human experience.

Chapter 6

Eye Candy

(2020-2021)

DIGITAL PERFORMANCE ART

In *Eye Candy*, Raghava KK transforms Instagram into a dynamic canvas, exploring seven universal emotions—love, loss, boundaries, truth, balance, introspection, and perspective. The project dissects each emotion through three conceptual layers: *Side A*, *Side B*, and *Play*, inviting audiences to engage with contrasting perspectives and find resolution through exploration.

Collaborating with Under25 Studios, *Eye Candy* leverages Instagram's tools—Reels, IGTV, Carousels, and Lives—to make art accessible to younger audiences while retaining the depth of traditional exhibitions. The project blurs the boundaries between storytelling, introspection, and digital art, offering a new vision for how art can connect and inspire in a digital-first world.

Explore the series: [@raghavakk](https://www.instagram.com/raghavakk)

Artist Statement for Eye Candy

When the world came to a standstill in 2020, I began to question the relevance of art in a world overwhelmed by chaos and uncertainty. Traditional galleries and physical spaces felt inaccessible, and yet, the need for connection, introspection, and emotional expression had never been more urgent. I realized that if art was to reach people where they were, it needed to evolve and meet them in their daily lives—on the screens we were all glued to.

This realization led me to Instagram, a platform synonymous with fleeting moments and quick consumption, but one that offered the potential to transform into a canvas for deeper, meaningful engagement. Collaborating with Anto Philip and Under25 Studios, I launched *Eye Candy*—a performance art project that reimaged the possibilities of digital storytelling.

At its heart, *Eye Candy* explores seven emotions: love, loss, boundaries, truth, balance, introspection, and perspective. Each emotion is expressed through three conceptual layers: *Side A*, which represents one perspective; *Side B*, its counterpoint; and *Play*, the space

where resolution or new understanding can emerge. This structure reflects my belief in the transcendent power of art to bridge divides, whether internal or external.

Using Instagram’s native tools—Reels, Carousels, IGTV videos, and Lives—I sought to create a hybrid exhibition that felt organic to the medium while maintaining the depth and complexity of traditional art. This wasn’t just about adapting art for a digital platform; it was about breaking the exclusivity of “high art” and inviting younger audiences to engage with themes that felt immediate and relevant to their lives.

Through *Eye Candy*, I wanted to demonstrate that art isn’t confined to galleries or museums. It can exist in the spaces where we already are, in the moments we scroll, swipe, and pause. It can spark reflection, connection, and even healing. For me, *Eye Candy* was not just an art project but a reminder of what art can do when it meets people in their reality and dares to create something transformative.

Explore *Eye Candy* on Instagram: [@raghavakk](#)

About Eye Candy (2020-2021)

Project Title: *Eye Candy*

Medium: Digital Performance Art

Year: 2020-2021

Platforms: Instagram

Collaborators: Raghava KK in partnership with Anto Philip and Under25 Studios

Project Concept

Eye Candy reimagines the boundaries of digital art by transforming Instagram into a canvas for performance art. This hybrid art show blends storytelling, visual art, and self-help, exploring seven emotions relevant to post-COVID times: love, loss, boundaries, truth, balance, introspection, and perspective. Each emotion is dissected through three conceptual layers: *Side A*, *Side B*, and *Play*. While *Side A* and *Side B* represent contrasting perspectives, *Play*

bridges them, inviting audiences to resolve tension through exploration and engagement.

Conceived during a time when the art world had largely come to a standstill, *Eye Candy* reflects Raghava KK's philosophy that art holds transcendent powers to imagine and create humanity's collective future. By choosing Instagram—a platform more familiar to younger audiences than traditional galleries—Raghava makes serious art accessible and relevant, breaking down barriers to entry.

Scope and Execution

Format

The project spans multiple Instagram features, including:

- **7 IGTV Videos:** Thematic deep dives exploring the seven emotions.
- **8 Reels:** Visual storytelling in bite-sized, dynamic formats.
- **14 Carousel Posts:** Contrasting perspectives illustrated through static visuals.
- **3 Instagram Live Sessions:** Interactive conversations with audiences.

Interactivity and Accessibility

By using Instagram as a medium, *Eye Candy* blurs the line between creator and audience. It leverages familiar tools—Reels, Carousels, and IGTV—to encourage reflective dialogue about the role of art in everyday life, particularly during times of crisis.

Artistic and Cultural Relevance

1 Breaking the Gallery Wall

- By choosing Instagram as its venue, *Eye Candy* challenges the exclusivity of traditional art spaces, making high art accessible to broader and younger audiences.

2 Themes of Emotional Exploration

- The project explores universal emotions, offering viewers a chance to reflect on their experiences during a period of global upheaval.

3 Blending Art and Self-Help

- By combining visual art with introspective storytelling, *Eye Candy* creates a space where art becomes a tool for personal growth and healing.

4 A New Canvas

- Instagram is dissected into its bare elements—Reels, Stories, Lives—and treated as a dynamic, interactive canvas.

Exhibition Context and Reception

Release and Reception

Launched on Instagram in February 2021, *Eye Candy* marked Raghava KK's debut on the platform. The project was met with overwhelming positivity, crossing 100,000 views across its seven episodes. In a time when social media was saturated with negativity, *Eye Candy* stood out for spreading hope, introspection, and creativity.

Collaborator Quote

- “We reimagined every possible construct around the world of art and digital storytelling, using Instagram as our venue for the exhibition. Each piece highlights the importance of playing between

contrasting sides to find one's unique personality." —Anto Philip,
Co-Founder of Under25 Studios

Key Themes

1 Duality and Resolution

- Each emotion is explored through contrasting perspectives (*Side A* and *Side B*), with *Play* as the space for resolution.

2 Art as Dialogue

- The project invites the audience into an ongoing conversation about their own emotions, fostering collective introspection.

3 Democratizing Art

- By using a universally accessible platform, *Eye Candy* bridges the gap between high art and popular culture.

Conclusion

Eye Candy transforms Instagram from a social media platform into a space for introspection, engagement, and creative exploration. By using familiar tools to deliver unfamiliar perspectives, it invites audiences to reflect on the role of art in shaping collective and individual futures. The project reaffirms Raghava KK's belief that art can transcend boundaries, offering connection and hope in times of uncertainty.

Chapter 7

Where the Wind Tastes of Forgotten Songs

WTWTOFS (2024)

Title: *WHERE THE WIND TASTES OF FORGOTTEN SONGS*

Artist: Raghava KK

Medium: Multidisciplinary Installation (Painting, AI, Projection Mapping, Sound Design)

Year: 2024

ABOUT THE EXHIBIT

Where the Wind Tastes of Forgotten Songs is an immersive art installation inspired by the transformative energy of the Himalayas. Combining painting, animation, artificial intelligence, sound design, and interactive projection mapping, the work reimagines the mountains as storytellers—capturing their vastness, fragility, and connection to human history.

The installation invites viewers into a participatory experience, where the winds of the Himalayas become metaphors for stories and memories carried across time.

This project transforms the Himalayas from a physical landscape into an experiential journey, blending traditional and digital mediums to explore themes of transformation, duality, and connection.

Artist's Note

Where the Wind Tastes of Forgotten Songs is a deeply personal project inspired by my journey into the Himalayas, a place where time feels suspended and the landscape speaks in whispers. The mountains, with their eternal presence and transformative energy, became a source of profound introspection for me. They are not just physical structures but storytellers, carrying the weight of history, myth, and the resilience of countless lives across centuries.

This project is my attempt to translate that experience into an immersive, multidimensional form. I wanted to bring the duality of the Himalayas to life—their grandeur and fragility, their raw power and intimate beauty. Through painting, drawing, animation, artificial intelligence, sound design, and projection mapping, I've sought to create a world where viewers can lose themselves in the winds of the mountains, hearing the echoes of forgotten stories and feeling the pulse of transformation.

For me, this installation is not just about the Himalayas; it's about what they represent—a journey into the self, a confrontation with

the past, and the possibility of harmony amidst change. It is a space where art, nature, and memory converge, inviting us to listen to the stories carried by the wind and reflect on our own.

About Where the Wind Tastes of Forgotten Songs

Overview

Where the Wind Tastes of Forgotten Songs is an immersive art installation by Raghava KK that draws inspiration from the Himalayas. Combining painting, drawing, animation, artificial intelligence, sound design, projection mapping, and interactive art, the project reimagines the mountains as storytellers. The installation captures the duality of the Himalayas—their vastness and fragility, their power and beauty—inviting viewers to engage with a world shaped by history, memory, and transformation.

Scope and Process

- **Mediums and Techniques:** Raghava KK integrates traditional and digital methods, using layered textures and vivid details to create an immersive environment.
- **Interactive Elements:** Projection mapping and AI-driven interactions make the installation participatory, allowing viewers to interact directly with its elements.

- **Thematic Focus:** The winds of the Himalayas act as a metaphor for the movement of stories and histories across time, anchoring the work in themes of transformation and connection.

Themes Explored

1 Transformation and Harmony: The Himalayas are presented as spaces of change and balance.

2 Nature as Storyteller: The landscapes are framed as carriers of memory and cultural resonance.

3 Duality of Experience: The work reflects contrasts—power and fragility, stillness and movement, intimacy and vastness.

Artistic Relevance

- **Immersive Storytelling:** By merging traditional art forms with AI and digital technologies, the installation redefines how stories are experienced.
- **Global Resonance:** While rooted in the Himalayas, the work speaks to universal themes of connection and transformation.
- **Engaging New Mediums:** The integration of interactive elements and AI broadens the possibilities for audience participation and engagement.

Closing

This project transforms the Himalayas from a physical space into a conceptual experience, offering viewers a unique journey through nature, history, and technology. *Where the Wind Tastes of Forgotten Songs* bridges the past and the future, encouraging reflection on the forces that connect us all.

Chapter 8

Break the Strings

IMMERSIVE INTERACTIVE ART INSTALLATION (IN Development)

Break the Strings invites participants into a world shaped by invisible forces of control—rules, expectations, and fears. This immersive experience guides you through a journey of self-awareness, challenging you to recognize and cut the symbolic “strings” that bind you.

Through interactive spaces that transform based on your actions, the installation evolves from a restrictive environment to one of freedom and creativity. The final stage becomes a collaborative canvas, where participants collectively shape a new, liberated reality.

Currently in development, *Break the Strings* is a work-in-progress, awaiting its full realization as a transformative art experience. It offers a powerful reflection on manipulation, agency, and the boundless possibilities of reclaiming your narrative.

Artist Statement for Break the Strings

Break the Strings began as a deeply personal reflection on my own experiences with manipulation, control, and the journey to reclaiming freedom. In many ways, it feels like the most vulnerable and honest project I've ever conceptualized. It's rooted in the moments where I've felt powerless—moments when the invisible strings of expectation, fear, and societal control dictated my choices and my identity.

This project is an attempt to visualize and externalize that internal struggle. It's about the systems we're all entangled in, some so pervasive that we barely notice them. Whether it's the pressure to conform, the expectations placed on us by loved ones or society, or the narratives we internalize about who we're supposed to be, these strings shape our lives in profound ways. But they can also be cut.

Break the Strings invites participants into a world that reflects these manipulations. The spaces are designed to feel restrictive at first, filled with cues that mirror the constraints we often face. But as you engage with the installation—cutting the strings, rejecting the

rules—you begin to transform the environment around you. It's an experience of reclaiming agency, where your actions literally shape the space.

For me, this project isn't just about breaking free; it's about what comes next. When the strings are gone, what will you create? How will you reimagine your world? The final phase of the installation is an open, collaborative space—a blank canvas for participants to build something new together.

I'm still in the process of bringing *Break the Strings* to life, and I see it as a collaboration not just with those helping to produce it but with every participant who will step into this world and make it their own. This project is my way of saying: You're not powerless. You're not bound. You have the ability to cut the strings, to rewrite the narrative, and to shape a reality that's truly your own.

About Break the Strings

Project Title: *Break the Strings*

Medium: Immersive Interactive Art Installation (In Development)

Status: Awaiting production and realization

Core Themes: Manipulation, empowerment, personal agency, and collective creativity

Project Concept

Break the Strings is an ambitious immersive art project that transforms the concepts of control and liberation into an interactive experience. Inspired by deeply personal experiences and universal struggles with manipulation, the project is envisioned as a space where participants confront the unseen forces that shape their choices and identities.

Through symbolic environments and dynamic participation, *Break the Strings* allows visitors to explore a narrative of manipulation and transcendence. The project challenges traditional storytelling by immersing participants in a world of invisible strings—rules, expectations, and fears—that dictate behavior, inviting them to cut these strings and reclaim their agency.

This work reflects the artist's exploration of themes like self-awareness, resistance to control, and the transformative power of creativity. It invites audiences to recognize the subtle, often insidious systems of control in their lives and empowers them to reject and reimagine these structures.

Scope and Process

Interactive Elements

1 Manipulative Environments:

- Spaces are designed to reflect oppressive systems, with physical and sensory cues representing restriction and control.
- Visitors navigate labyrinthine spaces where choices seem limited, mirroring real-world manipulations.

2 Breaking Free:

- Interactive tools allow participants to "cut" symbolic strings, revealing pathways to freedom and creativity.

3 Dynamic Evolution:

- The space transforms based on visitor interaction. As more "strings" are broken, the environment shifts from dark and rigid to vibrant and expansive.

Artistic and Technological Integration

- Combines physical installation, digital projections, and immersive soundscapes.
- Features interactive storytelling elements where participants influence the outcome through their actions.
- Incorporates reflective spaces encouraging introspection and self-discovery.

Philosophical and Emotional Core

Themes of Manipulation and Liberation

At its heart, *Break the Strings* explores the invisible mechanisms of control in our lives—whether personal, societal, or systemic. The project challenges participants to question their own willingness to comply with these forces and invites them to discover the power of resistance and creativity.

Empathy and Empowerment

By simulating the experience of being manipulated and then breaking free, the project fosters empathy for others who face similar struggles and inspires participants to reclaim their agency.

Transformative Creativity

The final phase of the experience transforms the space into a collaborative canvas where participants collectively shape their own reality, symbolizing the boundless possibilities of freedom and imagination.

Proposed Aesthetic and Audience Experience

Visual and Sensory Design

- **Initial Spaces:** Dark, angular, and oppressive, symbolizing control and rigidity.
- **Transformation:** As participants engage with the space, vibrant colors, flowing shapes, and organic textures emerge, representing freedom and creativity.

Soundscape

- Begins with discordant, repetitive tones to evoke tension and restriction.
- Gradually shifts to uplifting and harmonious sounds as participants transcend the manipulative structures.

Status and Museum Relevance

Break the Strings is currently in the conceptual and development stage, awaiting funding and institutional partnerships to bring it to life. Its themes and interactive nature make it an ideal fit for museums and art spaces dedicated to innovation, psychological exploration, and immersive experiences.

Potential Museum Fit:

- **M+ Museum (Hong Kong):** Aligns with its focus on interactive and experimental art forms.
- **The New Museum (New York):** Relevant for its exploration of social issues through contemporary art.
- **Serpentine Galleries (London):** Resonates with its focus on critical and participatory art practices.

Future Vision

As *Break the Strings* evolves from concept to reality, it holds the potential to become a transformative art experience. It invites audiences to reflect on their own lives, question systems of control, and embrace the creative power of agency.

This is not just an art installation—it is a call to action, a space for exploration, and a celebration of the human spirit's ability to transcend.

Chapter 9

Mysterium, Tremendum et Fascinans (MTF)

2018

tive works that explore the fluid nature of memory and selfhood, merging tactile imperfection with digital precision.

Exhibited at Artmatr Labs in Chelsea, New York City, MTF is a poignant commentary on reinvention, questioning fixed roles imposed by relationships, society, and technology. It invites viewers to embrace the interplay of human vulnerability and machine precision, bridging the past and future, the known and unknown.

Title: MYSTERIUM, TREMENDUM ET FASCINANS (MTF)

Artist: Raghava KK

Medium: Mixed Media: Robotic-Assisted Painting and Digital Art

Year: 2018

Exhibition: Artmatr Labs, Chelsea, New York City

BLENDING HUMAN CREATIVITY WITH ROBOTIC PRECISION, *Mysterium, Tremendum et Fascinans* (MTF) redefines transcendence as a deeply personal and transformative process. Inspired by Rudolf Otto's concept of the numinous—liberation, awe, and mystery—the series reflects the artist's journey of identity collapse and renewal during a period of profound upheaval. Collaborating with robotic systems X1, X2, and Sozo, Raghava KK creates itera-

Artist Statement for *Mysterium, Tremendum et Fascinans* (MTF)

When I embarked on creating *Mysterium, Tremendum et Fascinans* (MTF), I was navigating one of the most tumultuous periods of my personal and artistic journey. Over the past two years, my focus has been on exploring transcendence—not as a distant, theoretical concept, but as a deeply personal experience that intertwines with every aspect of our existence. This series is born out of my desire to infuse human intent into algorithms and geometries, crafting new forms of transcendent experiences that resonate with our current digital anthropocene.

MTF is a reflection of my evolving understanding of self and identity, influenced profoundly by the unraveling of a 17-year relationship. This period of intense emotional upheaval forced me to confront the very foundations of who I am and who I aspire to become. Collaborating with my brother Karthik, we delved into the essence of transcendence, borrowing from Rudolf Otto's definition of the numinous as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*—an attractive yet awe-inspiring mystery. We identified three core

elements essential to any transcendent experience: liberation, the loss of identity, and the comfort within mystery.

The project utilizes three robots—X1, X2, and Sozo—from Artmatr Labs to augment my creative process. These robotic collaborators allow me to reconfigure scientific reality into something humanly sublime, blending precision with spontaneity. Each piece in the *MTF* series is a unique dialogue between my emotional state and the machine's capabilities, capturing the fragmented and evolving nature of memory and identity. As I interact with these robots, I create multiple iterations of the same imagery, each one revealing different facets of my journey through loss, anger, despair, love, beauty, and rebirth.

MTF is not just an exhibition; it is a living, breathing entity that evolves with each viewer's interaction. The robotic marks and dynamic compositions symbolize the mutable nature of memory and the continuous process of self-reinvention. Every time I recreate a work, I am not merely recalling a memory but reshaping it, highlighting the interplay between the digital and the real. This process serves as a metaphor for my own struggle to let go of a defined identity and embrace the fluidity of becoming.

Exhibited at ArtMatr Gallery in Chelsea, New York City, *MTF* invites viewers to immerse themselves in a space where art becomes an experience of transformation. The installation challenges traditional notions of authorship and creativity, presenting a collaborative narrative where human emotion and machine logic coalesce to create something profoundly new. It is a testament to the power of art to navigate and transcend personal and societal constraints, offering a glimpse into a future where creativity is boundless and interconnected.

Through *MTF*, I aim to provoke thought and inspire a deeper understanding of our capacity for change and growth. It is an exploration of what it means to transcend—not by escaping our realities but by embracing and transforming them. This project embodies my belief that art is a continuous journey of becoming, an ever-evolving dialogue that keeps us feeling unsettled, curious, and ultimately, alive.

Explore *Mysterium, Tremendum et Fascinans (MTF)* at ArtMatr Gallery, Chelsea, New York City.

Visit ArtMatr Gallery

About *Mysterium, Tremendum et Fascinans* (MTF)

Project Title: *Mysterium, Tremendum et Fascinans* (MTF)

Medium: Mixed Media: Robotic-Assisted Painting and Digital Art

Year: 2018

Exhibition: Artmatr Labs, Chelsea, New York City

Core Themes: Transcendence, identity, loss, and reinvention

Project Concept

MTF is an immersive exploration of transcendence in the digital age, blending human creativity with robotic technology. The project's title, inspired by religious theorist Rudolf Otto's concept of the *numinous*, reflects three elements of transcendence: liberation, awe, and mystery. These themes are brought to life through

Raghava KK's deeply personal journey, captured in a series of works that engage with raw, transformative emotions.

The works in *MTF* were created using a groundbreaking collaboration between the artist and three robots—X1, X2, and Sozo—developed by Artmatr Labs. This fusion of human intent and machine precision allows for the repeated reimaging of images, where each iteration captures different aspects of the artist's experience of transcendence.

Scope and Process

Human and Machine Collaboration

- The project integrates human spontaneity with robotic consistency, where the robots become co-creators rather than mere tools. By feeding the same imagery into the robots, Raghava generates multiple, distinct versions of each work, each iteration amplifying different facets of his emotional and philosophical inquiry.

Thematic Exploration

- The works explore feelings of loss, liberation, and the unsettling mystery of the unknown, mirroring Raghava's personal experiences of identity collapse and renewal during a period of significant upheaval in his life.

Dynamic Layers

- The tactile marks created by the robots introduce an interplay between the digital and the real, embodying the idea that every memory or moment recalled is inherently altered in the process of remembering.

Artistic and Cultural Relevance

1 Redefining Transcendence

- Drawing on Otto's *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, the project explores transcendence not as a distant ideal but as a deeply personal and unsettling process of transformation.

2 Blurring Boundaries

- By combining robotics with traditional artistic techniques, *MTF* challenges the boundaries between human and machine, organic and synthetic, memory and reinvention.

3 Exploration of Memory and Identity

- The repetitive, iterative nature of the works reflects the fragmented and evolving nature of memory and identity, creating a powerful commentary on personal reinvention in the digital age.

Exhibition Overview

Venue:

Artmatr Labs, Chelsea, New York City—a hub for merging traditional painting techniques with cutting-edge digital technologies.

Key Works:

- A series of robotic-assisted paintings exploring stages of transcendence, including love, loss, despair, liberation, and rebirth.
- Abstracted forms that dissolve and reconfigure, symbolizing the fragmentation and reconstruction of identity.

Aesthetic and Sensory Design:

- Stark monochromatic tones infused with dynamic textures created by robotic precision.

- A blend of analog imperfections and digital precision to evoke both the tactile and the ephemeral.

Personal Connection

Artist's Journey

The project emerged during a period of profound personal transformation for Raghava KK, as he confronted the dissolution of a 17-year relationship. This experience reshaped his understanding of selfhood, identity, and the roles we inhabit in our relationships and society.

Ritual of Letting Go

As the works evolve across the series, the imagery of a central figure—representing his partner—becomes increasingly abstracted, dissolving into ethereal forms. This progression mirrors the artist's emotional journey of mourning, acceptance, and reinvention.

Key Themes

1 Transcendence Through Collaboration

- The use of robotic systems highlights how collaboration—whether with machines or other humans—can unlock new forms of creativity and transcendence.

2 Memory as a Mutable Construct

- The repetitive creation and reinterpretation of images reflect the fluidity of memory, where each recall subtly alters the original.

3 Liberation from Fixed Roles

- The works question the roles imposed by society, relationships, and the self, advocating for a fluid and evolving sense of identity.

Conclusion

MTF is a profound exploration of what it means to transcend—personally, artistically, and technologically. By merging human vulnerability with robotic precision, the series redefines the boundaries of art and identity, offering a deeply resonant commentary on reinvention in the digital age. Exhibited at Artmatr Labs in Chelsea, the project stands as a testament to the transformative power of art to bridge the human and the machine, the past and the future, the known and the unknown.

Chapter 10

Belief Economics

Book as an Art Project

TITLE: *BELIEF ECONOMICS: THE ARTIST RE-IMAGINING SYSTEMS*

Artist: Raghava KK

Medium: Mixed Media: Journals, Digital Art, AI-Powered Tools, and Philosophy

Year: 2024

ABOUT THE EXHIBIT

This exhibit is the culmination of Raghava KK's years of inquiry into belief, transformation, and the systems that shape our lives. Featuring over 500 digital and physical drawings from the artist's journals, it weaves together personal exploration, collaborative philosophy, and systemic critique to invite viewers into a reimagining of possibility.

Central to the exhibit is the *Economic Gyre*, a concept inspired by W.B. Yeats' vision of cyclical transformation, and the *Belief Pyramid*, a framework that maps the evolution of belief from recognition to integration. These ideas, forged through conversations with thinkers like Dr. Karthik Kalyanaraman and collaborations with emerging technology artists and curators, reflect a life lived in cycles of collapse, liberation, and reinvention.

Core Themes

- **Homo Mutans Philosophy:** Co-created with Dr. Karthik Kalyanaraman, exploring humanity's capacity for continuous transformation and adaptability.
- **Interactive Engagement:** Visitors can experience the *Belief Economics GPT*, an AI tool that reframes conflicts and offers creative solutions inspired by the book's frameworks.
- **Art and Experimentation:** The drawings act as provocations, reflecting the tensions, contradictions, and possibilities behind systemic and personal transformation.

Interactive Elements

Engage with the *Belief Economics GPT* to explore how belief can reframe challenges. The AI tool, built on the book's frameworks, helps navigate conflicts with creativity and a renewed perspective.

Artist Statement for Belief Economics

Artist Statement for *Belief Economics: An Artist Re-Imagining Systems*

It began with conversations with my brother, Dr. Karthik Kalyanaraman, as we wrestled with the idea of transformation in a rapidly changing world. Together, we co-created the *Homo Mutans* philosophy, exploring what it means to live as beings of perpetual change, defined not by fixed truths but by our ability to adapt, evolve, and transcend. These ideas culminated in our paper, *Transcendence for the Siri-O-Scene*, published in *Critical Collective*. That paper was both a theoretical foundation and a call to action—a provocation for how we navigate humanity's relationship with technology, belief, and the future.

Parallel to these conversations, Karthik and I co-curated the world's first AI art show in a gallery, an event that became the launchpad for many of the young technology artists and curators who are now shaping the global art world. Through that process, we worked to support, educate, and build a community of creators

in India, helping them find their voices and platforms in an emerging field.

Our conversations were restless, filled with questions that refused to settle: Is it valid to embrace multiple philosophies, or does that dilute their meaning? Should we live our lives perfecting a single truth, a philosophy treated as an aesthetic? Or can the act of navigating contradictions itself become an aesthetic—a way of living authentically in a world that defies simplicity? These questions stayed with me, unsettling and inspiring me in equal measure.

I carried these questions into the world, seeking experiments in every corner of life. I spoke at the Gujral Foundation about ethics, transformation, and the future. I collaborated with startups, helping them rethink logistics for India, build modular platforms for creators, and explore bio-hacking tools for the quantified self. Everywhere, I asked: What happens when we go beyond the market? What if our systems weren't just optimized for efficiency but designed for humanity?

These questions eventually crystallized into the frameworks that shape this book. The *Economic Gyre*, inspired by W.B. Yeats' cyclical vision of transformation, reflects the patterns of collapse, liberation, and reinvention I've seen in systems, in the world, and in my own life. The *Belief Pyramid* emerged as a lens to navigate belief—not as rigid truths to be perfected, but as dynamic forces that evolve through tension and integration.

This book poured out of me after a profound moment in the Himalayas, where the enormity of the mountains silenced my mind and left me with a strange, unknowable clarity. It is the culmination of years spent journaling, sketching, and asking better questions. Over 500 drawings from my journals accompany the

text, serving as visual provocations that reflect the tensions and insights behind the ideas.

But this is not just a book. It's an art experiment, a provocation to society. Included is the *Belief Economics GPT*, an AI tool where users can input their conflicts and explore creative, reframed solutions grounded in the book's frameworks. It invites readers to not only engage with these ideas but to apply them—to reimagine their systems, their challenges, and their lives.

At its heart, *Belief Economics* is a reflection of the questions that still keep me awake at night. It's an invitation to think beyond scarcity, markets, and fixed truths. It's a call to imagine systems rooted in trust, adaptability, and shared possibility. And it's a reminder that belief—the most fragile and powerful force we possess—can reshape everything, if we dare to let it.

This isn't just a book. It's a question, a map, a mirror, and an experiment. It's yours to continue.

About Belief Economics

Book as an Art Project

Scope and Process

Interdisciplinary Collaboration

The book, *Belief Economics: The Artist Re-Imagining Systems* is not just a literary or artistic endeavor—it is the culmination of a deeply personal and creative journey that integrates over 500 digital and physical drawings from the author's journals. These artworks serve as both anchors and amplifiers for the book's central ideas, illustrating how the author's life and art have mirrored the oscillations of the *Economic Gyre* and the *Belief Pyramid*.

Drawing inspiration from W.B. Yeats' vision of cyclical transformation, the project combines art, philosophy, and systemic critique to offer readers an immersive exploration of how belief shapes not only economies but also the very fabric of human experience.

- **Art and Journals:** Over 500 drawings accompany the text, creating a layered narrative where image and word interact to deepen meaning.

- **Philosophical and Poetic Foundations:** Rooted in the *Economic Gyre*, the project explores cycles of loss, liberation, and mystery, as informed by Yeats' gyre.

- **Interactive Technology:** Includes the development of a *Belief Economics GPT*, an AI-powered tool that uses the book's frameworks to help readers reframe conflicts and find creative solutions.

- **Personal Narrative:** The author's life mirrors the journey outlined in the book, moving through the tensions and transformations of belief and behavior.

Process

- **Conceptual Foundations:** The book blends the expansive systems of the *Belief Pyramid* with the structured frameworks of the *Economic Pyramid*, creating a cohesive lens for understanding both personal and systemic change.

- **Narrative and Visual Design:** Every chapter integrates journal drawings, using visual metaphors to reflect and expand on the text's ideas.

- **Interactive Solution-Finding:** The *Belief Economics GPT* transforms the book into a living framework, allowing readers to input their conflicts and receive creative, reframed solutions.

- **Art as Inquiry:** The drawings themselves were created as explorations of the book's themes, acting as visual reflections of the concepts and emotions that drive the narrative.

Deliverables

- **Book:** A text and art collection, integrating over 500 drawings to create an immersive experience.

- **Belief Economics GPT:** An AI-powered tool where users present conflicts and receive solutions grounded in the book's frameworks, helping them reframe their thinking and approach challenges with creativity and clarity.

- **Art Exhibitions:** Drawings exhibited alongside excerpts from the book, bringing the project into physical spaces where readers and viewers can interact with its ideas.

- **Workshops and Interactive Platforms:** Events and digital tools that invite readers to explore the concepts of the *Economic Gyre* and *Belief Pyramid* in their own lives.

Cultural and Intellectual Relevance

Reframing Systems Through Art and Technology

The project critiques traditional economic and social systems rooted in scarcity, offering belief as a dynamic, transformative lens. It bridges art, economics, and technology to create a living framework for systemic and personal change.

Interactive, Personalized Engagement

The inclusion of the *Belief Economics GPT* transforms the book into an active, participatory experience, helping users approach their conflicts with the creativity and insight that the book champions.

A Mirror of Cycles

The *Economic Gyre*, inspired by Yeats' vision, mirrors the author's life journey—oscillating between growth, collapse, and reinvention—and resonates universally with readers navigating their own cycles of change.

A Catalyst for Change

Through art, narrative, and interactive tools, the project challenges readers to not just understand belief but to apply it actively as a force for transformation.

Artistic and Technological Innovation

- **Dynamic Metaphors and Frameworks:** The *Economic Gyre* and *Belief Pyramid* offer new ways to understand and navigate complex systems and personal challenges.
- **Living Integration of Art and Narrative:** The interplay between the text and over 500 drawings creates a layered experience that moves beyond traditional books.
- **AI as a Companion for Change:** The *Belief Economics GPT* extends the book's impact, helping readers reimagine conflicts as opportunities for growth.

Closing Reflection

Belief Economics: The Artist Re-Imagining Systems is more than a book—it is an ecosystem of ideas, art, and interaction. By blending personal narrative with philosophical inquiry and technological innovation, it offers readers not only a framework for understanding belief but a toolkit for transforming their lives and systems. Through its drawings, text, and interactive GPT, the project embodies its core message: belief is a force that transcends boundaries, reshapes perspectives, and reimagines possibility.

Part Two

64/1

Chapter 11

Transcendence for the Siri-ocene

Title: *TRANSCENDENCE FOR THE SIRI-OCENE*

Creators: Karthik Kalyanaraman & Raghava KK (64/1)

Medium: Theoretical Essay and Art Philosophy

Year: 2018

TRANSCENDENCE FOR THE SIRI-OCENE REIMAGINES THE ROLE of art in a world shaped by artificial intelligence, automation, and ecological collapse. Published in *Critical Collective*, this manifesto challenges the stagnation in contemporary art criticism, critiquing its obsession with history and identity. Instead, it proposes a radical vision of the sublime—relational, participatory, and centered on co-creation between humans, machines, and systems.

Positioning artists as architects of the future, the work calls for a forward-looking aesthetic that embraces transformation and possi-

bility. It invites audiences to ask not just, “Why are we who we are?” but “What can we become?” In doing so, it challenges us to use art as a tool to shape humanity’s potential rather than as a reflection of its past.

From the Authors

Transcendence for the Siri-ocene is a manifesto for an era defined by radical change—a time when artificial intelligence, automation, and ecological collapse have transformed what it means to be human. In this essay, we asked ourselves: What role can art play in this future? Can it remain relevant as the world shifts beneath our feet?

The essay critiques the backward-looking tendencies of contemporary art criticism, particularly its fixation on history, identity, and situatedness. While these ideas have shaped much of modern discourse, we felt they no longer aligned with the challenges and possibilities of the present. Instead, we propose a new aesthetic—a “relational sublime”—where transcendence is participatory and incomplete, co-created by the artist, the audience, and even machines.

This work is deeply personal. It reflects our anxieties about the future and our belief in art’s potential to shape new worlds. At its

heart, the essay is an invitation: to reject nostalgia, embrace the unknown, and imagine who we could become if we dared to believe in our future selves. This is not just a critique—it is a call to action for artists, thinkers, and dreamers to step forward and shape the cultural imagination of the Siri-ocene.

About Transcendence for the Siri- ocene (2018)

Overview

Transcendence for the Siri-ocene, published in *Critical Collective*, is a manifesto for a future-facing art practice and philosophy. It critiques the stagnation in contemporary art criticism and proposes a bold, utopian vision for transcendence in art. This project reimagines the relationship between humanity, technology, and the sublime in an era defined by rapid automation and ecological uncertainty.

Background and Context

The essay emerged as a response to the melancholia and backward-looking tendencies that dominate art theory in the aftermath of postmodernism. Drawing on the philosophy of Nietzsche, Deleuze, and Kant, the work critically examines Westernized art discourses that emphasize immanence, identity, and historical situatedness. It challenges these notions, particularly as they overlook the Global South's unique perspectives on progress and possibility.

The authors, Karthik Kalyanaraman and Raghava KK, argue that our era demands a forward-looking aesthetic that engages with humanity's evolving nature in the face of artificial intelligence, automation, and ecological crises. The essay envisions a future where the central question shifts from "Why are we who we are?" to "What can we become?"

Core Ideas

1 Critique of Stagnation

- The essay identifies a pervasive sense of "the end of history" in art and culture, a Eurocentric worldview that limits the imagination of the future.
- It critiques the reduction of art to debates between biology and culture, calling instead for a vision of art that embraces possibility and transformation.

2 Reimagining Transcendence

- Rejects traditional notions of transcendence based on absolutes like God or Truth.
- Proposes a new relational and incomplete sublime that is co-created by the subject and the artwork. This sublime symbolizes the radical potential of the future, experienced affectively rather than cognitively.

3 A Manifesto for Future Art

- The essay envisions artists as active participants in shaping humanity's future, rather than passive commentators on the past.
- Future artists must engage with participatory practices, technological mediation, and the integration of machine intelligence into creative processes.

- The "relational sublime" becomes the guiding aesthetic for an era where machines can outmatch human cognitive tasks but not human imagination and emotional depth.

Influence and Legacy

The essay serves as a roadmap for artists navigating the Siri-ocene—an age shaped by Siri-like AI, automation, and environmental challenges. It pushes the boundaries of traditional art criticism by positioning art as a tool for imagining and enacting alternative futures.

Theoretical yet grounded in practical provocations, *Transcendence for the Siri-ocene* invites readers and creators to reject nostalgia and embrace the unknown. It aligns with 64/1's mission to blur the boundaries between art, criticism, and education, setting the stage for their future projects like *Gradient Descent* and *Strange Genders*.

This manifesto remains a critical reference point for artists and thinkers exploring the intersections of art, technology, and human potential.

Chapter 12

Gradient Descent

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The exhibition challenged traditional notions of authorship and creativity, presenting AI as a collaborator rather than a competitor. From algorithmic portraits to dynamic installations, *Gradient Descent* demonstrated how machines can expand the boundaries of artistic practice and provoke new questions about the future of art.

Gradient Descent was not just an exhibition—it was a provocation. It invited audiences to ask: Can machines be creative? And if so, what does that mean for humanity? Through its dialogue between human and machine, the exhibit redefined art as a shared exploration of possibility in the age of technology.

Title: *GRADIENT DESCENT*

Creators: Curated by 64/1 (Karthik Kalyanaraman & Raghava KK)

Medium: Artificial Intelligence Art Exhibition

Year: 2018

ABOUT THE EXHIBIT

Gradient Descent was the world's first AI art show hosted in a mainstream gallery, Nature Morte in New Delhi. Curated by 64/1, this groundbreaking exhibition explored the intersection of human creativity and machine intelligence, showcasing works by pioneering AI artists such as Mario Klingemann, Anna Ridler, Harshit Agrawal, Memo Akten, and others.

From the Authors

Gradient Descent was born from a deep curiosity about the potential of artificial intelligence to transform human creativity. We saw AI not as a replacement for human ingenuity but as a collaborator—a new lens through which we could explore the limits of artistic expression.

Curating this show at Nature Morte Gallery in New Delhi was our attempt to bring AI art into mainstream cultural discourse. By featuring a diverse range of AI-generated works, from algorithmic portraits to dynamic installations, we wanted to challenge audiences to rethink what it means to create and experience art in the age of machines.

For us, *Gradient Descent* wasn't just an exhibition—it was a question. Can machines truly be creative? And if so, what does that mean for human identity, authorship, and imagination? This project invited artists, audiences, and technologists to grapple with these questions, knowing there are no easy answers. It was the

beginning of a much larger conversation—one that continues to evolve as we navigate the rapidly shifting boundaries between human and machine.

About Gradient Descent (2018)

Overview

Gradient Descent was the world's first artificial intelligence (AI) art show hosted in a mainstream gallery, Nature Morte in New Delhi. Curated by 64/1, the exhibition explored the evolving relationship between human creativity and machine intelligence. By showcasing works from some of the world's most innovative AI artists, the show offered audiences a glimpse into how technology is reshaping the boundaries of artistic practice.

The exhibition wasn't just about technology—it was about what it means to be creative in an age where machines can generate art, solve problems, and mimic human cognition. It questioned whether creativity is an exclusively human trait and how we might coexist with machines in the creative process.

Key Features

- **Artists:** Featured works by leading AI artists such as Mario Klingemann, Memo Akten, Anna Ridler, Harshit Agrawal, Jake Elwes, and Tom White.
- **Installations:** Included interactive and algorithmic pieces, from AI-generated portraits to dynamic, ever-changing landscapes.
- **Curation Philosophy:** Positioned the gallery as a space for dialogue between human and machine, showcasing the potential for collaboration rather than competition.

Themes Explored

1 Human-Machine Collaboration: Highlighted how AI can serve as a tool and partner for creative expression, expanding the possibilities of art-making.

2 Questioning Creativity: Challenged traditional notions of authorship, intent, and originality by presenting works co-created with AI systems.

3 Technological Sublime: Invoked awe and curiosity, presenting technology not as a threat but as a source of creative potential.

Impact and Legacy

Gradient Descent marked a turning point in the art world, cementing AI art as a legitimate practice and sparking global conversations about the role of technology in creativity. It helped launch the careers of emerging AI artists while making their work accessible to new audiences. The exhibition remains a cornerstone of 64/1's mission to blur the boundaries between art, criticism, and innovation.

This project demonstrated that AI is not just a tool but a medium through which humanity can explore its own evolution, creativity, and future. *Gradient Descent* continues to inspire curators, artists, and technologists to rethink the relationship between art and machines.

Chapter 13

Future Bets

64/1

make strategic investments in 15 companies across traditional and futuristic industries. Real-time events—climate shifts, policy changes, and technological breakthroughs—shape the market, requiring players to balance short-term gains with long-term vision.

This is more than a game; it is an artful exploration of risk, ethics, and imagination. Played by corporations and institutions worldwide, *Future Bets* transforms the act of trading into a provocation: What kind of future are we building? And what role will you play in shaping it?

“Rethink tomorrow—one decision at a time.”

Title: *FUTURE BETS*

Creators: 64/1 (Karthik Kalyanaraman & Raghava KK)

Medium: Interactive Performance Installation and Economic Simulation

Year: 2019

ABOUT THE EXPERIENCE

Future Bets is a groundbreaking experiential project that transforms decision-making into an act of creativity and foresight. Originally commissioned by Ashika Capital and later expanded globally by Limitless Institute, the project challenges participants to navigate a simulated future spanning 2022 to 2040.

Blending the intensity of a stock market simulation with the immersive power of live theatre, *Future Bets* invites participants to

Note from the Authors

Future Bets began as an experiment to transform trading into a reflective and imaginative experience. Commissioned by Ashika Capital, it was designed to challenge participants to look beyond immediate returns and consider the broader, long-term consequences of their decisions. By navigating speculative scenarios that blend creativity, strategy, and ethics, participants were encouraged to explore the far-reaching impacts of their actions.

Through immersive simulations, live performances, and dynamic storytelling, the project bridged the realms of finance and art. It allowed players to confront uncertainties, test their foresight, and reimagine their relationship with risk and reward. What began as a localized project quickly gained traction, and with the support of Limitless Institute, *Future Bets* evolved into a global initiative that reached diverse audiences across industries.

For us, this work represents more than a game—it is a platform for provoking thought and inspiring action. By engaging with the

complexities of tomorrow, *Future Bets* invites participants to think differently about the challenges ahead and their role in shaping a more thoughtful and sustainable future.

About Future Bets (2019)

Overview

Future Bets, originally commissioned by Ashika Capital and later transformed into a global movement by Limitless Institute, is an experiential performance art project that challenges participants to reimagine their relationship with risk, reward, and long-term thinking. Combining the intensity of a simulated stock market with the immersive power of live theatre, the game pushes participants to navigate a rapidly evolving future and confront the ethical, economic, and imaginative implications of their decisions.

This project was conceived as an intersection of art and strategy, turning abstract concepts of disruption, foresight, and sustainability into tangible, actionable experiences. It has since been played by corporations and institutions worldwide, earning praise for its unique ability to merge creativity with practical insights into future readiness. *The Economic Times* called it “a transformative tool for rethinking the possibilities of tomorrow.”

Scope and Process

- **Game Mechanics:** The experience is set between 2022 and 2040, with each in-game year lasting five minutes. Participants trade shares of 15 companies spanning traditional and futuristic industries, responding to dynamic events such as policy changes, climate disruptions, and technological advancements.
- **Market Simulation:** Real-time stock fluctuations are guided by beta values derived from expert interviews and research, creating a realistic and responsive market environment.
- **Immersive Storytelling:** Live theatre performances, video montages, newsletters, and interviews immerse participants in evolving scenarios, making every decision feel urgent and impactful.
- **Strategic Engagement:** Participants start with fixed in-game currency and must build the strongest portfolio by the end of the simulation, balancing short-term gains with long-term vision.

Themes Explored

- 1 Future Preparedness:** Encourages participants to anticipate disruptions and strategize for uncertainty.
- 2 Ethics in Decision-Making:** Challenges players to align investment choices with broader societal and environmental outcomes.
- 3 Imagination as Strategy:** Demonstrates how speculative thinking can lead to innovative and impactful decisions.

Artistic and Cultural Relevance

Reframing Risk

Future Bets elevates risk-taking into an act of creative exploration, encouraging participants to move beyond the transactional mindset and engage with the possibilities of a better future.

Blurring Boundaries

The project seamlessly integrates performance art with economic simulation, using the language of finance to provoke deeper questions about humanity's collective aspirations.

Expanding the Conversation

From its origins as a commission by Ashika Capital to its global expansion by Limitless, *Future Bets* has inspired thousands to rethink how they approach the future. It has been played in boardrooms, institutions, and conferences, turning strategy into an artful dialogue.

Closing Reflection

Future Bets is not just a game; it is a provocation. It challenges participants to internalize the drivers of disruption and imagine their role in shaping tomorrow. By blending art, economics, and immersive performance, the project transforms decision-making into a deeply human act of creativity, ethics, and foresight. This is art at its most impactful—a tool for imagining and enacting futures that transcend the limits of the present.

Chapter 14

A Species of Change?

64/1

as apocalyptic, but as opportunities for transformation and ecological renewal.

This cover challenges us to rethink the symbols we hold dear and their relevance in a world shaped by accelerating change. It is both a mirror of our past and a call to imagine a future where creativity turns crises into catalysts for thoughtful evolution.

“Can the same technological drive that accelerates crises also inspire ecological living?”

TITLE: *A SPECIES OF CHANGE?*

Creators: 64/1 (Karthik Kalyanaraman & Raghava KK)

Medium: Conceptual Artwork for *Marg* Magazine Cover

Year: 2020

ABOUT THE ARTWORK

Created for the 75th anniversary issue of *Marg*, India’s premier art magazine, *A Species of Change?* reinterprets the wheel—a timeless symbol of continuity in Indian culture—as a metaphor for humanity’s evolving relationship with technology and nature.

The artwork juxtaposes a red bovine, symbolizing raw natural power, with a technologically driven cart, highlighting the tension between tradition and innovation. Through deliberate parody, it critiques standard conceptualism, urging viewers to see crises not

Authors Note

For *Marg's* 75th anniversary, we wanted to create something that was more than a celebration—it had to be a provocation. The cover, *A Species of Change?*, reflects our ongoing exploration of how humanity navigates moments of crisis, particularly in the interplay between tradition, technology, and ecological transformation.

The wheel, an enduring symbol in Indian culture, became our anchor—a metaphor for continuity and progress, but also for the tension between past and future. By juxtaposing a red bovine, a nod to raw, natural power, with a cart driven by technological momentum, we sought to highlight the fragile balance between what we preserve and what we innovate.

This artwork is a deliberate parody of conceptual art, meant to critique the stagnation in the movement while also pushing its boundaries. It invites viewers to see the current crises—not as apocalyptic endpoints—but as opportunities for rethinking, reimagining, and rebuilding our relationship with the biosphere and each other.

We hope this work sparks reflection, not only on the past 75 years of *Marg*, but also on the paths we're carving into the future. Art, for us, remains the ultimate catalyst for seeing crises as a species of change.

About A Species of Change?

(2020)

Marg Cover

A Species of Change? (2020)

Overview

To commemorate the 75th anniversary of *Marg*, India's premier art magazine, 64/1 created a conceptual artwork for the cover titled *A Species of Change?*. This work used deliberate parody and symbolism to provoke reflection on the interplay between technology, crisis, and ecological transformation. By drawing from the cultural and historical significance of the wheel as a motif, the artwork juxtaposes tradition with modernity to question humanity's trajectory in the face of accelerating change.

The cover art stood as both a critique and a vision—inviting viewers to see the challenges of the present not as apocalyptic, but as an opportunity for transformation.

Scope and Process

- **Thematic Focus:** The wheel, an emblem of continuity in Indian culture, is reinterpreted to symbolize humanity's relationship with technology and nature amidst crisis.
- **Conceptual Parody:** Through a playful yet incisive approach, the artwork critiques standard conceptualism, encouraging viewers to rethink its depth and relevance.
- **Art as Provocation:** Designed to foster a dialogue about how technological progress can either perpetuate crises or inspire sustainable, creative futures.

Visual Elements

- A red bovine harnessed to a modern cart, symbolizing the juxtaposition of raw natural power with technological innovation.
- Subtle references to ecological living and the impact of technology on everyday human experience.

Themes Explored

- 1 Crisis as Opportunity:** Challenges viewers to reframe crises as catalysts for creativity and ecological transformation.
- 2 Tradition Meets Technology:** Explores how enduring cultural symbols like the wheel can take on new meanings in a changing world.
- 3 Critique of Conceptualism:** Provokes deeper engagement with conceptual art, moving beyond clichés to offer layered interpretations.

Impact and Legacy

Marg Cover: A Species of Change? epitomizes 64/1's philosophy of using art as a tool for critique and inspiration. By blending cultural history with contemporary urgency, it engages viewers in reimagining humanity's relationship with technology and the environment.

This project reinforces the potential of art to serve as both a mirror and a map—reflecting the complexities of the present while charting pathways toward a more thoughtful and sustainable future.

Chapter Fifteen

Author's Note

Strange Genders emerged from our shared curiosity about how technology, particularly artificial intelligence, can challenge and expand traditional constructs of identity. The project began with a simple yet profound question: What happens when we ask AI to interpret and reimagine something as deeply ingrained and culturally loaded as gender?

To create this work, we collaborated with Harshit Agrawal and engaged with the people of Bengaluru, asking over 1,000 individuals to draw their interpretations of male and female forms. These drawings became the foundation for training an AI model that could generate fluid, non-binary representations—visuals that defied the rigid binaries of gender and celebrated its inherent complexity.

The process itself was as transformative as the output. The AI did not merely replicate human ideas of gender; it created something that transcended them, offering a glimpse into identities that might feel unfamiliar but deeply resonate in a post-human context.

Exhibiting this work globally—from Kolkata to Turin, and Milan to Nvidia’s AI Gallery—allowed us to share this provocation with diverse audiences, sparking conversations about technology’s role in reshaping identity and inclusion.

For us, *Strange Genders* is not just about gender; it is about fluidity, possibility, and the intersection of human imagination with machine potential. It invites viewers to look beyond the limitations of the past and imagine identities that are more expansive, inclusive, and true to the diversity of human experience.

About Strange Genders (2020)

Overview

Strange Genders is a collaborative AI art project by 64/1 (Karthik Kalyanaraman and Raghava KK) and Harshit Agrawal that challenges traditional gender binaries through the lens of artificial intelligence. By leveraging AI algorithms, the project generates fluid, non-binary representations of gender, prompting viewers to reconsider preconceived notions of identity in a digital and post-human context.

The project has been showcased in several prestigious venues, including:

- **Exostential – An AI Art Show** at Emami Art Foundation, Kolkata. [citeturnosearcho](https://www.citeturnosearcho.com/)
- **NVIDIA AI Art Gallery.**

- **PhotoVogue Festival** at BASE Milano, Milan, in November 2023.

- **Hub India – A Spectacular and Unique Art Exhibition** in Turin, Italy, curated by Myna Mukherjee and Davide Quadrio. citeturnosearch8

Additionally, *Strange Genders* was longlisted for the prestigious Lumen Prize, recognizing its impact in the field of AI art.

Scope and Process

- **Data Collection:** The artists collected drawings from approximately 1,000 individuals in Bengaluru, who were asked to sketch male and female figures. citeturnosearcho

- **AI Training:** These drawings were used to train AI algorithms to understand and generate human figures, allowing the AI to produce images that blend characteristics traditionally associated with both genders.

- **Artistic Output:** The AI-generated images were curated into installations that challenge the binary perception of gender, presenting a spectrum of identities that reflect the fluidity and complexity of human gender expression.

Themes Explored

1 Deconstructing Gender Norms: By using AI to merge and reinterpret traditional gender representations, the project questions the rigidity of societal gender classifications.

2 AI as a Creative Collaborator: The project exemplifies how artificial intelligence can be harnessed as a tool for artistic exploration, pushing the boundaries of creativity and challenging human biases.

3 Cultural Reflections: Through the integration of diverse human inputs and AI processing, the artwork reflects on cultural perceptions of gender and how technology can both mirror and influence these views.

Artistic and Cultural Relevance

Challenging Perceptions

Strange Genders confronts viewers with AI-generated art that defies traditional gender norms, encouraging a reevaluation of personal and societal perceptions of identity.

Innovative Use of Technology

The project showcases the potential of AI in the arts, not merely as a tool but as an active participant in the creative process, capable of producing thought-provoking and culturally relevant works.

Global Recognition and Exhibition

The inclusion of *Strange Genders* in international exhibitions and its recognition by the Lumen Prize highlight its significance in the global art scene, particularly in discussions at the intersection of technology, art, and identity.

Closing Reflection

Strange Genders serves as a catalyst for dialogue on the fluidity of gender and the role of technology in shaping our understanding of

identity. By merging human creativity with artificial intelligence, the project opens new avenues for exploring and expressing the complexities of human existence in the digital age.

Chapter 16

Art as Art Criticism

64/1

Title: *ART AS ART CRITICISM*

Creators: 64/1 (Karthik Kalyanaraman & Raghava KK)

Medium: Conceptual Art Series

Year: 2020

ABOUT THE EXHIBIT

Art as Art Criticism is a provocative series that critiques and reimagines the possibilities of conceptual art. Created as both parody and earnest exploration, each piece questions the stagnation of contemporary conceptual practices while offering fresh perspectives on its potential.

The series includes works like *History of Western Painting from Birth to Death*, which abstracts iconic Western artworks into color fields to critique commodification, and *Imagining Poverty*, *Imag-*

ining Wealth, where children's interpretations of economic disparity expose societal conditioning. Other pieces, like *Tanjore Stripped Bare by Her Contemporary Artists*, juxtapose traditional Indian art forms with modern conceptual aesthetics, exploring tensions between authenticity and innovation.

THIS SERIES BLURS THE BOUNDARIES BETWEEN CRITIQUE AND creation, challenging viewers to rethink their assumptions about art's purpose and power. *Art as Art Criticism* is both a mirror and a call to action, asking: How can art transcend its own clichés and remain worth revisiting?

“What makes an artwork demand a second encounter in a world of single-use images?”

Artist's Note

Art as Art Criticism was born from a deep desire to interrogate and reinvigorate the stagnation we observed in contemporary conceptual art. The movement, once radical and revolutionary with Marcel Duchamp's subversion of the “retinal,” has often devolved into a formulaic practice of gestures that appear conceptual but lack the depth to challenge or inspire. Our goal was not merely to critique this trend but to use the language of conceptual art itself to push the boundaries of what it can be.

This project asks: What happens when art becomes its own critique? Each work in the series embodies this question by blurring the lines between commentary and creation. For example, *History of Western Painting from Birth to Death* reduces iconic Western artworks to their average colors and hues, offering a visual critique of commodification and the flattening of historical complexity into consumable data. In *Tanjore Stripped Bare by Her Contemporary Artists*, we explored the interplay between traditional Indian art forms and modern conceptual aesthetics, high-

lighting the tension between cultural authenticity and innovation. Meanwhile, *Imagining Poverty*, *Imagining Wealth* uses children's interpretations of wealth and poverty to expose societal conditioning, reflecting on how even the youngest among us absorb and replicate economic hierarchies.

We also played with irony and sincerity, inviting viewers to hold both at once. Each artwork exists at a threshold: it is at once a parody of the clichés of conceptualism and an earnest attempt to reimagine its possibilities. This duality is intentional—it is meant to provoke reflection, encouraging viewers to reconsider their assumptions about art, its purpose, and its ability to evoke something more than mere intellectual acknowledgment.

The works are not answers but provocations. Through *Art as Art Criticism*, we wanted to ask fundamental questions: What makes art worth revisiting in an age of single-use images? Can conceptual art transcend its own clichés? And how can art criticism itself be a creative act, one that expands the possibilities of art rather than simply evaluating it?

For us, this series is both a reflection of our respect for conceptual art's history and a challenge for its future. It is an invitation to artists, critics, and audiences to think beyond established boundaries and imagine a richer, more daring field of possibilities.

About Marg: Art as Art Criticism (2020)

Overview

For *Marg*, India's premier art magazine, 64/1 created a conceptual series titled *Art as Art Criticism*. The project sought to challenge the clichés and stagnation of contemporary conceptual art by using art itself as a medium of critique. Each piece in the series was both a parody and an earnest exploration, addressing the evolution of conceptual art since Marcel Duchamp's era and its entrenchment in overused tropes.

By blending critique with creativity, the series pushed the boundaries of art criticism, encouraging both artists and audiences to reevaluate the depth and purpose of conceptual practices.

Scope and Process

- **Thematic Focus:** Examined the history of conceptual art, critiquing its reliance on formulaic gestures while advocating for innovation and renewal.

- **Medium:** The works employed irony, parody, and layered symbolism to critique conceptual art's tendency toward intellectual posturing.

- **Art as Critique:** Each piece embodied a critical commentary, inviting viewers to engage with the work both visually and conceptually.

Examples of Works

1 History of Western Painting from Birth to Death: A visual commentary on the commodification of art, represented through digitally abstracted color fields based on the averages of famous paintings.

2 Tanjore Stripped Bare by Her Contemporary Artists: A reimagining of Tanjore painting styles, blending traditional craft with modern conceptual aesthetics to question authenticity and innovation.

3 Imagining Poverty, Imagining Wealth: A provocative piece involving children's interpretations of wealth and poverty through painted dolls, reflecting societal conditioning and economic disparity.

Themes Explored

1 Critique of Formulaic Conceptualism: Questions the creative stagnation in contemporary art practices that rely on predictable techniques and intellectualized gestures.

2 Playful Subversion: Uses parody and humor to provoke deeper engagement with the medium and message of conceptual art.

3 Reinvigorating Art Criticism: Advocates for a more dynamic, experimental approach to critiquing art, merging intellectual rigor with creative expression.

Artistic and Cultural Relevance

Redefining Criticism

Art as Art Criticism breaks the traditional boundaries between art-making and critique, offering a model where the two can coexist and enrich each other.

Cultural Commentary

By incorporating elements of Indian tradition, such as Tanjore art, into the dialogue, the series situates its critique within a broader cultural and historical context.

Engaging Audiences

The project invites viewers to question their assumptions about art and its purpose, fostering a more participatory and reflective experience.

Closing Reflection

Marg: Art as Art Criticism challenges artists and audiences alike to move beyond surface-level conceptualism and engage with the deeper possibilities of art. Through its playful yet incisive critique, it serves as both a mirror and a call to action, asking: What makes art worth revisiting? How can we keep it alive, relevant, and transformative?

Chapter 17

Meaning Hackathon

64/1

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THE *MEANING HACKATHON* DEMONSTRATED THAT ART-making is not confined to galleries or specialists. It provided a space for experimentation, collaboration, and direct engagement with contemporary art, fostering creativity in a new generation.

TITLE: *MEANING HACKATHON*

Creators: 64/1 (Karthik Kalyanaraman & Raghava KK)

Medium: Workshop and Mobile Art Installations

Year: 2023

ABOUT THE EXHIBIT

Developed for Under 25, India's largest student festival, the *Meaning Hackathon* introduced students with no prior art background to contemporary aesthetics. Through a rapid, hands-on workshop, participants created mobile art installations using everyday materials.

The completed works were exhibited during the festival, transforming the students into creators and contributors to a public art space.

Artists Note

The *Meaning Hackathon* was an experiment in making contemporary art accessible to those who might never have considered themselves artists. Held as part of Under 25, India's largest student festival, it was designed for participants with no prior art experience, emphasizing hands-on creation and collaboration.

For us, the goal was simple: to demystify art. We wanted to show that contemporary aesthetics isn't confined to galleries or institutions—it can emerge from everyday materials and ideas. The students, working within a short time frame, embraced the challenge, creating mobile installations that reflected their perspectives and experiments with form and meaning.

Seeing their work exhibited within the festival context underscored the importance of creating platforms where anyone can engage with art, not just as an audience but as contributors. The *Meaning Hackathon* wasn't just about making—it was about shifting perceptions of who art is for.

About The Meaning Hackathon (2023)

Overview

The *Meaning Hackathon* was developed by 64/1 as part of Under 25, India's largest student festival. Designed for participants with no prior art background, the project was a rapid workshop in contemporary aesthetics. Students were introduced to foundational concepts and guided through the process of creating mobile art installations, which were exhibited during the festival.

The hackathon sought to make art accessible and engaging for younger audiences, emphasizing hands-on experimentation and collaborative creation.

Scope and Process

- **Workshop Structure:** Participants were given a crash course in contemporary art practices and aesthetics.
- **Creation Process:** Students worked in small groups to

conceptualize and construct mobile art installations using simple, readily available materials.

- **Exhibition:** The finished works were displayed within the festival grounds, allowing participants to experience their creations as part of a public art space.

Themes Explored

1 Accessibility: Introduced contemporary art in a format that was open to non-specialists.

2 Experimentation: Encouraged quick, iterative thinking and problem-solving through art-making.

3 Collaboration: Highlighted the importance of collective creativity.

Impact

The *Meaning Hackathon* brought contemporary art into a space traditionally dominated by youth and popular culture. By allowing participants to engage with art through direct creation, the project encouraged a broader understanding of aesthetics and its relevance to everyday life. The public exhibition of the works allowed participants to see their creations in a larger context, reinforcing the value of their contributions.